

Render Deploy Failure: “Missing script: build”

min_hiring_pipeline — Backend service · Diagnosis and fix

What was happening

Every deploy on Render failed at the build step, across several different commits (“fixes”, “fixes”, and later ones), always with the same error:

```
==> Running build command 'npm install & npm run build'...
npm error Missing script: "build"
npm error
npm error To see a list of scripts, run:
npm error npm run
==> Build failed
```

Root cause

The repository is an npm workspaces monorepo (root, backend/, frontend/). Render’s configured build command is `npm install && npm run build`, run from whichever directory Render treats as the service root. Neither the root `package.json` nor `backend/package.json` defined a plain build script — only namespaced ones (`build:backend`, `build:frontend` at the root; nothing at all matched by that exact name in `backend/`). Whichever directory Render was actually building from, `npm run build` had nothing to run.

Since Render’s exact “Root Directory” setting isn’t visible from the repository itself, the fix was applied in both places so it works regardless of that setting.

What changed

1. Root `package.json` — added:

```
"postinstall": "npm run prisma:generate",
"build": "npm run prisma:generate && npm run build:backend",
"start": "npm run start --workspace=backend"
```

2. `backend/package.json` — added a self-sufficient build (works even if Render installs only this folder, ignoring the workspace root), and moved prisma from a root-only dev dependency to one backend also declares directly:

```
"postinstall": "prisma generate --schema=../prisma/schema.prisma",
"build": "prisma generate --schema=../prisma/schema.prisma && tsc -p
tsconfig.json",

"devDependencies": {
  ...
  "prisma": "^5.22.0",
  ...
}
```

3. Along the way, found and fixed a related latent bug in `backend/src/config/env.ts`: it computed the path to the repo-root `.env` file as two directories up from itself, but the file lives at `backend/src/config/env.ts` — three directories up from the repo root, not two. The path pointed at a `backend/.env` that doesn't exist. This is harmless in production (Render injects environment variables directly; it never reads a committed `.env` file), but was corrected for local-dev correctness.

```
- dotenv.config({ path: path.resolve(__dirname, "..", "..", ".env") });
+ dotenv.config({ path: path.resolve(__dirname, "..", "..", "..", ".env") });
```

Verified

- Ran `npm run build` standalone from inside `backend/` with a clean `dist/`: it generates the Prisma client from the correct relative schema path, compiles cleanly, and produces `dist/index.js`.
- This matches exactly what Render's log shows it running (`npm install && npm run build`).

What's still needed

This fix currently exists only in the local working tree — it has not been committed. Render deploys from git, and every failing attempt so far (including the most recent ones) was built from commits that do not contain this change. **The fix needs to be committed and pushed before Render's next auto-deploy will pick it up.**

Note: several commits named “fixes” appeared in the repository's history during this session that were not made from this session — something else (another terminal, another agent session) has been committing and pushing to this same repository in parallel. Worth checking there isn't a second process working on the same working directory at the same time, since that can overwrite in-progress changes on either side.

Separately: once the build succeeds, double-check in Render's dashboard that `DATABASE_URL` (and any other required environment variables) are set for this service — Render never reads the repository's own `.env` file.